

The Sarcoma Caregiver's Guide

Supporting a Loved One Through Diagnosis and Treatment

Practical advice on navigating appointments, managing side effects, protecting your own wellbeing, and accessing support as a caregiver.

Sarcoma Hub | Patient & Caregiver Series | Document 4 of 6

Last reviewed: 2025 | Category: Patient Leaflet | All Sarcoma Types

You Are Not Alone

When someone you love is diagnosed with sarcoma, your life changes too. Caregivers — whether partners, parents, children, or friends — play an irreplaceable role in the sarcoma journey. This guide is written for you: to help you understand the disease, support your loved one effectively, and take care of yourself along the way.

REMEMBER: You cannot pour from an empty cup. Attending to your own physical and mental health is not selfish — it is essential to sustaining the care you provide. Caregiver burnout is real and affects both of you.

Understanding the Diagnosis

As a caregiver, you will hear a lot of unfamiliar medical terms. It helps to learn the basics so you can participate meaningfully in conversations and help your loved one process information:

- **Sarcoma** — a cancer of the connective tissues (bone, muscle, fat, nerve, blood vessel). Not one disease but a family of 70+ distinct cancers.
- **MDT (Multidisciplinary Team)** — the group of specialists who plan your loved one's treatment together. Ask to attend or receive notes from MDT discussions.
- **Pathology report** — the definitive report confirming diagnosis, subtype, grade, and margins. Request a copy and bring it to all appointments.
- **Grade** — how aggressive the tumour appears. High-grade tumours tend to grow faster.
- **Stage** — how far the cancer has spread. Stage I-II is localised; Stage III-IV involves spread to lymph nodes or distant organs.

Practical Ways to Help

At appointments:

- Attend appointments with your loved one — two pairs of ears remember more than one.

- Take notes during consultations, or ask permission to record the conversation.
- Prepare a list of questions together before each appointment.
- Ask for clarification when medical language is unclear — 'Could you explain that in simpler terms?'
- Request written summaries or patient letters after each key appointment.

Day-to-day practical support:

- Organise a transport rota for appointments — accept offers of help from others.
- Keep a shared digital folder or notebook with all medical documents, scans, and letters.
- Manage medications — create a written schedule and set reminders.
- Prepare nutritious, easy meals — particularly important during chemotherapy.
- Help manage fatigue by protecting rest time and planning activities for higher-energy periods.
- Handle communications with family, employers, and insurance if your loved one is overwhelmed.

Managing Common Treatment Side Effects

Your loved one's oncology team is the best source of advice on managing side effects. The table below summarises common issues and helpful strategies:

Side Effect	Helpful strategies for caregivers
Fatigue	Plan activities for best-energy times (often mornings). Short rest periods, not long daytime sleep. Gentle exercise if cleared by medical team.
Nausea & appetite loss	Small, frequent meals. Ginger tea or ginger sweets. Anti-nausea medications should be taken proactively before meals. Avoid strong smells during chemotherapy.
Mouth sores (mucositis)	Frequent gentle salt-water or baking soda rinses. Soft, bland foods. Avoid acidic, spicy, or very hot/cold foods. Good oral hygiene with soft toothbrush.
Infection risk (neutropenia)	Strict hand hygiene. Avoid crowds and those with illness during low-immunity periods. Report any fever >38°C/100.4°F immediately to the oncology team.
Hair loss	Prepare emotionally — hair loss is temporary with most regimens. Cold cap therapy may reduce loss with some chemotherapy protocols. Scarves, hats, and wigs are available.
Emotional distress	Acknowledge it — anxiety, depression, and grief are normal. Encourage professional support: psychologist, support groups, and counselling are available.
Pain	Report all pain to the medical team. Do not wait until the next appointment. Effective pain management is available and is a priority in sarcoma care.
Swelling / lymphoedema	Elevate limbs where possible. Specialist lymphoedema nurses can provide compression garments and drainage massage techniques.

Looking After Yourself

Research shows that caregiver mental health directly affects patient outcomes. If you are struggling, please reach out for help. Seeking support for yourself is one of the most important things you can do for your loved one.

- **Sleep** — prioritise it. Disrupted sleep impairs decision-making, patience, and immunity.
- **Maintain connections** — do not isolate yourself. Accept help from friends and family.
- **Set boundaries** — it is healthy to acknowledge what you cannot do.
- **Seek professional support** — counselling, therapy, and support groups exist for caregivers.
- **Take breaks** — respite care is available in many areas. Using it is not abandonment.
- **Stay physically active** — even short walks significantly improve mental health.
- **Practical help** — social workers attached to the oncology team can connect you to financial support, transport, and home care.

Resources for Caregivers

- **CancerCare** (cancercares.org) — free counselling and support groups for caregivers.
- **Cancer Support Community** (cancersupportcommunity.org) — caregiver resources and peer support.
- **Sarcoma Foundation of America** (curesarcoma.org) — financial assistance programmes for families.
- **Sarcoma Hub Community Forum** — connect with other sarcoma caregivers in our Community Forum tab.
- **Caregiver Action Network** (caregiveraction.org) — advocacy and practical resources for all caregivers.

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